Castro knew that he could not stop the Soviets from doing what they wanted to do. His new strategy was to extract as many concessions from the Americans as possible for the removal. “Our position is as follows,” Castro told the Soviet envoy: “tie the removal of the naval blockade and the cessation of the violation of Cuban airspace to the withdrawal of IL-28 bombers.” He then concluded with a threat: “Without these requirements, we cannot give our consent.”[8]

Withdrawing the bombers in exchange for lifting the blockade had been the Soviet position from the start, but stopping overflights of Cuban territory was a tricky proposition. The Americans insisted on them as a substitute for on-ground inspections, which Castro opposed. Mikoyan protested the overflights at his meeting with Stevenson in New York on November 1. He knew that there was no way of convincing the Americans to stop the overflights in exchange for removal of the bombers. Meanwhile, Castro was adamant about stopping the overflights. “The Americans are insolent,” he argued. “They make shaving flights over Cuban territory, flying at 100 meters over our military bases and units. This is bad for the morale of our people and makes them resentful. Our position led to the point that now our enemy knows everything.”

When Mikoyan pushed for the need to lift the naval blockade, Castro asked him a direct question: “Will this position include the requirement to cease the violation of our airspace?” Mikoyan refused to link the overflights with the removal of the bombers. “We consider such flights to be illegal,” he told Castro. “You are planning to send your protest to the UN. It will be a serious warning to the Americans.” In short, the answer was no.[9]

Castro took offense. There were no conversations with Mikoyan on the following day, November 14, and no plans for meetings on November 15. A top-ranking member of the Soviet Presidium was sitting in Havana in an atmosphere of growing tension between Washington, Moscow, and Havana with nothing to do and no one to meet. Mikoyan was alarmed and felt spurred to action. He asked Ambassador Alekseev to invite the Cuban leadership to dinner at the Soviet embassy on the evening of November 16. Probably to Mikoyan’s surprise, Castro accepted and, even more surprisingly, was all congeniality. He embraced his Soviet friend, diminutive in comparison to him, in a bear hug. In fact, he had a surprise